

DRIVING IN THE RAIN

LA EDITION

INTRODUCTION

Rain in Southern California is one of the most underestimated driving hazards. Long dry periods allow oil, dust, and debris to build up on road surfaces. When it first rains, these contaminants rise to the surface, creating extremely slippery conditions. Add reduced visibility, standing water, and unpredictable traffic behavior, and the risk of collisions increases sharply. This module covers how to prepare, how to adjust your driving, and how to respond safely when traction is reduced.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Wet roads significantly reduce tire traction and increase stopping distance..
- The first rain after a dry period is often the most dangerous.
- Visibility drops due to spray, glare, and fogged windows.
- Many rain-related crashes are preventable with simple driving adjustments.



PREPARATION BEFORE AND DURING RAIN

- Turn on headlights when using windshield wipers. Use low beams only.
- Make sure windshield wipers and defroster are working properly.
- Ensure tires are properly inflated and have adequate tread depth.
- Avoid using cruise control in wet conditions
- Keep windows clear of fog using the defroster or A/C.

SPEED AND FOLLOWING DISTANCE

- Reduce speed below the posted limit when roads are wet
- Increase following distance to at least 3–5 seconds behind the vehicle ahead.
- Use smooth, gentle steering, braking, and acceleration.
- Avoid sudden maneuvers that can break traction.

HYDROPLANING: WHAT IT IS AND WHAT TO DO

Hydroplaning occurs when a layer of water builds between your tires and the road surface, causing the tires to lose contact with the pavement. This can happen at moderate speeds, especially in standing water or with worn tires.

- If you begin to hydroplane, ease off the accelerator.
- Do not slam on the brakes.
- Keep both hands on the wheel and steer in the direction you want the vehicle to go.
- Once traction returns, gently stabilize your speed.

VISIBILITY AND LANE POSITION

- Use the defroster to prevent windows from fogging.
- Be aware of glare from headlights reflecting off wet pavement, especially at night.
- Water tends to pool in outer lanes. When safe, use center lanes to reduce hydroplaning risk.
- Increase distance when following large trucks and buses due to heavy spray.

EMERGENCY AND SAFE PRACTICES

- After driving through deep water, lightly tap the brakes to help dry them.
- Avoid driving through standing water when possible. Depth can be misleading.
- If visibility or control becomes unsafe, pull over in a safe location and wait for conditions to improve.
- Stay calm and focused. Most rain-related incidents are caused by panic reactions or overcorrection.

LA-SPECIFIC REMINDERS

- The first rain after long dry periods is often the most slippery.
- Freeway on-ramps, off-ramps, and right lanes often collect standing water.
- Night driving in rain requires extra caution due to glare and faded lane markings.

**RAIN CHANGES THE ROAD.
CHANGE HOW YOU DRIVE.**

IT'S OK TO GET HOME LATE AS LONG AS YOU GET HOME SAFE